



A PRACTICAL PARENTING GUIDE

How to Raise a Disciplined Child Without Constant Shouting

A Practical Guide for Nigerian Parents to Build Respect, Responsibility, Good Habits and Self-Control

CALM LIMITS. CLEAR EXPECTATIONS. CONNECTION THAT LASTS.

A warm, realistic guide for everyday family life — from homework and chores to screens, siblings and big feelings.

A NOTE BEFORE YOU BEGIN

You do not have to get it perfect.

This guide is for the parent who has repeated the same instruction five times, raised their voice, and later wished the moment had gone differently. It is for the parent doing school runs, work, meals, bills, care for relatives and the invisible planning that keeps a home moving. You are not a bad parent because you feel tired or lose patience. You are a human being carrying a lot.

The aim is not a silent house or a child who never makes mistakes. It is a home where expectations are clear, adults follow through without fear, and children get repeated chances to practise responsibility. Change usually comes through small, steady actions—not one perfect conversation.

A safety note

This guide does not support hitting, humiliation, insults, threats or frightening a child into obedience. If anyone is at immediate risk of harm, create safety first and seek trusted local help.

How to use this guide

- Choose one recurring behaviour first. Do not redesign your whole home this week.
- Read the short scripts aloud and adapt them to your own voice, language and family values.
- Print the worksheets or copy them into a notebook. Review them with children where age-appropriate.
- Expect practice, not instant change. A child may need many calm reminders before a new habit sticks.

Nigerian homes are not all the same. Family structure, language, faith, housing, work schedules and available support differ. Keep the principles; adapt the routines. Mothers, fathers, grandparents and other caregivers can use the same agreed words and limits.

Start small

If you only have ten minutes, go to Chapter 3, pick one rule from Chapter 4, then use the seven-day reset. The printable pages are designed to be reused.

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PART I

Foundations

Understand what discipline really is, why behaviour repeats, and how to pause before you react.

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WELCOME

Introduction — From shouting to teaching

A more useful response starts by understanding what is happening for both of you.

Most parents do not wake up planning to shout. It often begins with a reasonable request: get ready for school, put away the uniform, stop fighting, finish your food, hand over the phone. Then there is delay, arguing or silence. The clock is moving. You are already carrying work, transport, money or household worries. Your voice rises because it feels like the only thing that gets a response.

That reaction is understandable—and it can still be changed. Repeated shouting may stop a behaviour for a moment, but it does not reliably show a child what to do next time. It can shift the lesson from “I should put the plate away” to “I should avoid being caught” or “the loudest person wins.” A child may comply out of fear without learning planning, repair or self-control.

A calmer approach is not permissive. You can be warm and firm at the same time: “I hear that you want to keep playing. It is bath time now. You can walk with me, or I can help you get started.” Then you follow through. Connection makes it easier to teach; the limit remains real.



A realistic goal

Not “my child never argues.” Try: “I will give one clear instruction, make sure my child heard it, and follow through without insults.” Measure your own next step as well as your child’s progress.

This guide aligns with public parenting guidance emphasizing clear expectations, positive attention, realistic limits and calm consequences. Sources are listed at the end.

CHAPTER 01

What discipline really means

01

Discipline is teaching a skill—not proving who is in charge.

Discipline means helping a child learn what is expected, practise it, and repair harm when things go wrong. The word is connected to learning. A child is still developing attention, emotional control, planning and judgment. They need adults to lend structure while those abilities grow.

Approach	What it teaches
Discipline	“Here is the expectation; here is how to practise it.”
Punishment	“Something unpleasant will happen because you did wrong.”
Fear or control	“Stay quiet or avoid being caught.”

A consequence may be part of discipline, but it is not the whole lesson. Teaching also includes showing the behaviour, giving a chance to practise, noticing effort, and helping the child put things right.

Try this instead

When a child spills water while rushing: “Pause. Get the small towel and wipe the floor so nobody slips.”
The limit is clear, and the child learns a repair skill.

Ask yourself

- What do I want my child to learn for next time?
- What support or practice would make that possible?
- Can I hold the boundary without attacking the child?

CHAPTER 02

Why children repeat the same behaviours

02

Repetition is information. It is not always a deliberate challenge to your authority.

Children may ignore, delay, argue or melt down for different reasons. They may not have heard you over noise; the instruction may be too broad; the task may feel difficult; they may be hungry, tired or absorbed; or they may be testing whether a limit is predictable. Sometimes a behaviour has become a quick way to get adult attention or postpone an unwanted task.

- **“I told him to behave.”** A young child may not know what that means. Name the action: “Feet on the floor; sit beside me.”
- **“She knows better.”** Knowing a rule and remembering it while upset are different skills. Practise it when calm.
- **“He always waits until the last minute.”** A long homework task may need a starting routine and short work periods.
- **“They fight every evening.”** Hunger, crowding, one shared device or an unclear turn-taking rule may be part of the pattern.



Look for the pattern

For three days, note what happened just before the behaviour, what the child did, and what happened next. This is curiosity, not blame. A pattern can show you where a routine or instruction needs to change.

In a busy home with siblings, visitors or several caregivers, the same child may hear different rules from different adults. A calm family agreement can reduce that confusion.

Related tool

Use the Behaviour Tracker (Tool 4) to record the pattern. **See page 33.**

CHAPTER 03

The Calm Parent system

03

Five steps to replace the first angry reaction with a teachable response.

Step	What you do	Purpose
1 • PAUSE	Take one slow breath; lower your shoulders.	Settle your body.
2 • UNDERSTAND	Notice the trigger; ask what is getting in the way.	Respond to the real problem.
3 • STATE	Say one clear expectation.	Show the next action.
4 • CONSEQUENCE	Name a connected, fair next step.	Make the limit predictable.
5 • FOLLOW THROUGH	Do what you said without a lecture.	Teach responsibility.

Example: homework has not started

- **Pause:** unclench your jaw; take one slow breath.
- **Understand:** “You are still on the game. Is the assignment confusing, or are you not ready to stop?”
- **State:** “Homework starts now. Put the phone on the shelf and bring your books to the table.”
- **Consequence:** “If the work has not started, there will be no game until the agreed work period is done.”
- **Follow through:** help the child get started; keep the boundary without a speech.

When safety is urgent

Stop unsafe behaviour first with few words. Move people apart or remove a dangerous object. Explain and problem-solve later, when bodies are calmer.

What to say when the heat rises

Short words help you stay steady. You can come back to the full conversation later.

Instead of escalating	Try a calm, firm line
“How many times will I tell you?”	“The instruction is still the same: shoes on the rack now.”
“You are being impossible.”	“You are upset. The limit is still that we leave now.”
“Keep quiet or else!”	“Use a lower voice. I will listen when we can both speak safely.”
“You never help.”	“Please put these plates by the sink before you sit down.”

A 10-second reset

If you feel close to shouting, say: “I am getting frustrated. I will take a minute and come back.” Make sure children are safe, step away briefly, breathe, drink water, or wash your face. Return when you can speak without threatening.

A quick self-check

- Am I responding to danger, or to inconvenience?
- Have I named one next action rather than listing every past mistake?
- Is this the time to teach, or should I make things safe and talk later?

Related tool

Keep the Parent Calm-Down Checklist (Tool 6) somewhere you will see it. **See page 35.**



PART II

Building the Structure

Clear rules, clear instructions and fair consequences give children something predictable to lean on.

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CHAPTER 04

Set clear family rules

04

A few visible agreements work better than a long list nobody can remember.

Aim for five to eight family rules. Write them as actions people can practise, not labels like “be good.” Involve children in naming what makes home safe, respectful and workable. Adults still set the safety boundaries; children can help decide how to meet them.

Too broad	Clear and teachable
Respect everybody	Use safe hands and speak without insults.
Do your work	Homework begins after snack and before entertainment.
Keep the house clean	Put your plate by the sink after eating.
Be responsible with devices	Charge devices in the agreed family spot at bedtime.

Make each rule pass four tests

- **Specific:** can a child see or hear what it means?
- **Realistic:** can the child do it at their age and in your home?
- **Positive:** does it say what to do, not only what to stop?
- **Consistent:** can the adults explain and follow it most days?

Caregivers on the same page

Agree privately on key rules and consequences where possible. If a grandparent or other caregiver differs, discuss one shared safety rule rather than correcting one another in front of the child.

Related tool

Write your rules on Our Family Rules (Tool 1) and post it where everyone can see. **See page 30.**

CHAPTER 05

Stop repeating yourself

05

Get close, get attention, give one doable instruction, then check it was heard.

From another room, across a noisy living room, “Get ready!” can disappear into the background. Before repeating, move near the child, say their name, pause until they look or respond, and give one action. For a young child, show the first step. For an older child, ask them to repeat the plan back.

Weak or vague	Short and clear
“Sort yourself out.”	“Put on your uniform and bring your socks here.”
“Stop being careless.”	“Zip the school bag and place it by the door.”
“You know what to do.”	“Put your plate by the sink now, please.”
“Do not make a mess.”	“Keep the crayons on this paper; wipe the table when you finish.”

Useful scripts

“Please put your shoes away now.” • “Homework comes before phone time.” • “You may be angry, but you may not hit your brother.”

Give a reasonable amount of time. If the child does not begin, calmly repeat once and name the next step: “The shoes are still on the floor. Please put them away now; then we can leave.” Avoid stacking five new commands on top of the first.

CHAPTER 06

Consequences without shouting

06

A consequence should teach or protect—not settle an adult’s anger.

A fair consequence is connected to what happened, reasonable for the child’s age, explained briefly, and something you can calmly carry out. A child who spills a drink helps wipe it. A child who misuses a toy pauses play with that toy until it can be used safely. A teen who misses the agreed phone hand-in time may have the next session shortened or supervised.

Situation	Teaching response	Avoid revenge
Toy thrown	Pause that toy; practise safe play later.	"No toys for a month."
Chore not done	Finish it before the next agreed privilege.	Adding chores in anger.
Phone used past limit	Phone rests in agreed spot until next planned time.	Taking it indefinitely.
Bedtime delayed by screens	Screens end earlier tomorrow; reset routine.	Shaming in front of visitors.

Before you decide

Does it connect to the behaviour? Is it proportionate? Is it safe? Is it realistic to follow through? Can I explain it in one sentence? If not, pause and choose later.

Natural consequences are not always safe

Do not let a child face danger, hunger, unsafe transport or school harm just to "learn a lesson." Adults remain responsible for protection.

Related tool

Plan ahead with the Consequence Planner (Tool 5). **See page 34.**



PART III

Everyday Situations

Tantrums, ages and stages, chores, homework, screens, back-chat and sibling fights — with words you can use today.

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CHAPTER 07

Tantrums and emotional outbursts

07

The job is safety first, teaching second. A flooded child cannot take in a lecture.

Before an outburst

- Notice predictable pressure points: hunger after school, a rushed morning, tiredness, stopping a game, sharing a device.
- Prepare a transition: “Ten more minutes, then save your game and come for dinner.”
- Offer two acceptable choices when possible: “Blue shirt or green shirt?”

During the outburst

- Lower your voice and use fewer words. Keep people and objects safe.
- Stay nearby if safe. Do not argue, threaten, mock or demand an apology in the heat of the moment.
- Name the boundary: “I will not let you hit. I am moving your brother away.”
- If you are losing control, ask another safe adult to take over or step away briefly while the child is safe.



Words that help

“You are very upset. I am here. I will listen when your body is safer.” Acknowledge the feeling; do not give in to unsafe behaviour.

After the storm: reconnect, then teach

Wait for calm. A short repair conversation is more useful than a long speech.

After the outburst

- **Reconnect:** “That was hard. I love you, and the hitting still was not okay.”
- **Ask briefly:** “What happened just before you got that angry?” Listen without turning every answer into a debate.
- **Practise a replacement:** ask for a turn, say “I need help,” stomp safely, or move to a quiet place.
- **Repair harm:** check on a sibling, help rebuild, wipe or replace what was damaged where reasonable.
- **Plan one change:** earlier warning, snack first, a timer, or adult support at the trigger point.

If it happens in a public place

Move to a safe, quieter spot if possible. Use a brief line: “We are going outside to settle; we can talk when you are ready.” Do not perform for onlookers or shame the child.

Outbursts differ by child and situation. This guide does not diagnose their cause. If behaviour is frequent, intense, unsafe or disrupting daily life, seek individualized advice from an appropriate qualified professional or trusted local service.

CHAPTER 08

Discipline for different ages

08

The boundary can stay firm while the amount of help changes.

Ages 3–5 • show, simplify, repeat

Use one-step directions, predictable routines and two small choices. Expect reminders and help with transitions. Consequences should be immediate and brief: “Blocks are for building. If you throw them, I will put them away until after snack.” Praise the action you want repeated.

Ages 6–9 • practise routines together

Children can remember simple household rules but still need visual cues, adult check-ins and help breaking jobs into steps. Use a checklist for the morning, school bag or chores. Let them redo or repair a task rather than labelling them careless.

Young-child expectation	Adult support
Put toys away	Sort into labelled basket together.
Get ready	Picture routine; one prompt at a time.
Wait for a turn	Use a short timer and practise words.

Ages 10–12 • plan, check, coach

Invite your child to help plan homework blocks, screen limits and chores. Use natural reminders—calendar, checklist or agreed alarm—before stepping in. If a responsibility is missed, discuss how to put it right and adjust the plan. Do not confuse one forgotten task with a character flaw.

Ages 13–15 • negotiate boundaries, protect safety

Teenagers need growing privacy and input, along with clear expectations about safety, respectful speech, school responsibilities and device use. Discuss rules before a conflict. Explain which parts are non-negotiable (safety) and where there is choice (when to do a chore before the agreed deadline).

Age band	Shift toward	Keep doing
10–12	Planning, checklists, shared problem-solving.	Clear limits and warm check-ins.
13–15	Negotiation, privacy, responsibility for choices.	Safety boundaries and follow-through.

Conversation starter

“You are getting older, and I want us to agree on a plan you can own. What would help you finish the task by 7 p.m.? What should happen if it is still not done?”

Remember

Development varies. These are broad guideposts, not tests or diagnoses. Make the task easier or provide more help when the child is tired, learning something new or facing a change.

CHAPTER 09

Chores, responsibility and independence

09

Children belong to the family team; chores are practice, not a test of worth.

Choose jobs that fit the child’s ability, teach the steps, and keep expectations consistent. Start small. A child may do a task more slowly or less neatly than an adult. If you redo it silently every time, they may learn that the task belongs to you. Show what “done” looks like, then allow practice.

Age	Possible home contributions (adapt to the child)
3–5	Put toys in a basket, carry light clothing, place napkins.
6–9	Make bed with help, sort laundry, water plants, set table.
10–12	Sweep a small area, pack own school bag, help prepare a simple snack.
13–15	Manage own laundry steps, help plan a meal, keep shared spaces tidy.



Try a start-up routine

“After breakfast, plate to sink; before screen time, complete the agreed chore.” Link chores to routines rather than using every task as a bargaining chip.

Safety comes first: supervise tools, heat, cleaning products, water and road-related tasks. Keep chores fair across children and avoid treating one child as the default caregiver for siblings.

Related tool

Agree jobs on the Weekly Chore Chart (Tool 2). **See page 31.**

CHAPTER 10

Homework, school and study habits

10

Reduce arguments by making the start predictable and the task visible.

Homework battles often begin before the first question: the child is hungry, the assignment is unclear, books are missing, or everyone expects a different start time. Build a simple after-school sequence that fits your home: arrive, wash, snack or rest, homework, pack the bag, then agreed recreation.

A low-drama homework routine

- Set a regular place with light, books and stationery. It can be one end of the dining table.
- Ask the child to show the assignment and choose which subject to start, if there is a choice.
- Break large work into short chunks with a planned movement or water break.
- Stay available without doing the work for them. Ask: “What is the first question asking?”
- Use a visible finish line: “When these two tasks are checked, pack your bag.”

Script for the start

“You have had a snack and a short rest. It is homework time. Bring your books; we will choose the first task together.”

If homework repeatedly causes distress, check for practical barriers: unclear instructions, missing materials, an overloaded schedule or a subject the child finds hard. Contact the teacher respectfully to understand expectations. Avoid calling a child lazy when you do not yet know what is getting in the way.

CHAPTER 11

11

Phones, TV, gaming and social media

Technology can be part of family life; boundaries make it more manageable.

A workable screen plan names when screens are available, what must happen first, where devices sleep, and which content needs adult guidance. Choose rules your family can actually maintain. A blanket “no technology ever” may not fit school, work or modern family life.

Family question	Possible agreement
When are screens off?	During meals, homework focus time, and the agreed bedtime wind-down.
Where do devices charge?	In a shared family spot overnight, if practical.
What comes first?	Essential schoolwork, agreed chores and face-to-face responsibilities.
What if a limit is ignored?	Device rests until the next agreed screen period; review the plan calmly.

Make stopping easier

Give a warning, agree where to save, and use a timer if helpful: “Five minutes left. Save at the next checkpoint.” Keep the limit even if the child protests.

For older children, include privacy, online kindness, scams, sharing images and what to do if something feels unsafe. Stay curious rather than turning every disclosure into an automatic punishment; children are more likely to seek help when they expect to be heard.

CHAPTER 12

When your child talks back

12

Disagreement is not automatically disrespect. Teach the line between the two.

A child can disagree, feel disappointed or ask why without being rude. Insults, threats, mocking and shouting over someone need a boundary. When the tone is heated, respond to the behaviour—not the challenge to your status.

Child says...	Parent can say...
"This rule is unfair."	"You can disagree. Tell me what feels unfair without insulting me."
"I don't want to."	"I hear you. The task still needs doing. Do you want to start now or after five minutes?"
An insult or threat	"I will listen to your point, not to insults. We will pause and try again."
"You never listen!"	"Maybe I missed something. Tell me your main point in a calm voice."

Do not compete for the last word

Say the boundary once. If everyone is getting louder, pause and return to the issue when calm. A parent can be firm without demanding instant agreement.

Later, revisit the original issue and hear the child's concern. Repair is for adults too: "I interrupted you. I am ready to listen now."

CHAPTER 13

Sibling fights

13

Keep everyone safe; do not decide the whole story while emotions are high.

In the moment

- Stop hitting, pushing or throwing. Move children apart and check for injury.
- Use a neutral line: “I will not let anyone hit. We are separating for now.”
- Do not force an immediate apology or label one child “the troublemaker.”
- When calm, hear each child briefly. Ask what each person needs to make things safer.
- Help them choose a repair: return the item, rebuild, take turns with a timer, or ask an adult for help.



Useful intervention script

“Pause. Hands down. I will listen to each person. You can both be angry; nobody gets to hurt anyone. First, we will make sure everyone is safe.”

Some conflict is ordinary practice in sharing space, but recurring intimidation or significant harm needs adult protection and a closer plan. Do not leave a younger or vulnerable child responsible for stopping an older sibling’s aggression.



PART IV

Connection and Repair

Correct the behaviour without breaking confidence, and repair well when you lose your temper.

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CHAPTER 14

Correct behaviour without breaking confidence

14

Separate the action from the child's identity.

Children need to know a behaviour was not acceptable. They do not need to believe that they themselves are bad, lazy or hopeless. Identity labels can close the door to learning: if a child is “the careless one,” why try to improve? Name what happened and what to do next.

Instead of...	Try...
“You are lazy.”	“You did not complete your responsibility. Let us make a start plan.”
“You are a bad child.”	“That behaviour was not acceptable. You can make it right.”
“You are so careless.”	“The water spilled. Get a cloth and wipe it with me.”
“You always spoil everything.”	“The game was damaged when it was thrown. We need to pause and repair.”

Correct privately when you can

In front of visitors or relatives, use a brief safety reminder. Save a longer conversation for a private moment. Protecting dignity does not mean hiding harm or dropping a necessary boundary.

The message is: **“You are loved and capable of learning. This action still needs to change.”**

CHAPTER 15

The power of praise and positive attention

15

Notice the specific effort you want to see again.

When adults mostly notice trouble, a child can learn that disruption is the fastest route to attention. Look for small, real moments of cooperation: starting after one reminder, waiting for a turn, putting a cup away, telling the truth or calming down after frustration.

Make praise specific and sincere

- “You put your bag by the door without a reminder. That helped our morning.”
- “You were angry and still used words instead of hitting. That took effort.”
- “Thank you for giving your sister a turn when the timer rang.”
- “You kept trying that sum even when it was difficult.”

Praise is not a bribe, and it does not have to be dramatic. A warm look, a thank-you or a few minutes of focused attention can mean a lot. Do not praise only outcomes such as high marks; notice practice, honesty and repair.



Five minutes of connection

Ask about the child's day while preparing dinner, folding clothes or walking home. Put the phone aside and follow their lead for a few minutes. Connection does not need an expensive outing.

CHAPTER 16

What to do when you lose your temper

16

A difficult moment is not the end of the relationship. Repair is part of the lesson.

If you shouted, start by settling yourself. Do not demand that the child comfort you or accept your apology immediately. Take responsibility for your part while keeping the original boundary.

A simple repair

- **Name it:** “I shouted at you earlier.”
- **Own it:** “That was not okay, and it was my responsibility to speak more calmly.”
- **Reassure:** “I love you. You are not responsible for managing my feelings.”
- **Keep the limit:** “The phone still needs to be put away at bedtime.”
- **Restart:** “Next time I will pause before I speak. Let us try the routine again.”

If the pattern is repeating

Notice your triggers: rushing, noise, lack of support, money pressure, or the same conflict at the same time each day. Make one practical change and seek support from a trusted adult or appropriate professional if you need it. Asking for help is responsible parenting.

Apologising does not remove parental authority. It models accountability: when we hurt someone, we acknowledge it and work to do better.

Related tool

Use the Parent Calm-Down Checklist (Tool 6) to plan your repair. **See page 35.**



PART V

Put It Into Practice

One small step each day for a week. Adapt the pace to your household.

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CHAPTER 17

The 7-day Calm Discipline reset

17

One small step each day. Adapt the pace to your household.

Day	Focus	Small action
1	Identify one problem	Write when it happens, what comes before it and what follows.
2	Create family rules	Choose up to six clear rules; explain one calmly.
3	Improve instructions	Get close; use one short action and check it was heard.
4	Introduce consequences	Choose one connected, safe, realistic response and state it before it is needed.
5	Introduce routines	Choose one pressure point—morning, homework or bedtime—and write the steps in order.
6	Reinforce good behaviour	Name three specific actions you appreciated. Give a few minutes of focused attention.
7	Review and adjust	Ask what helped, what was hard, and what one change to test next week.

Days 5–7 turn a one-time intention into a repeatable family practice. Do not measure success by whether your child tests the rule. Measure whether the expectation is clearer and whether you followed through more calmly than before.

A 10-minute family review

- What went a little better this week?
- Which rule or instruction was confusing?
- Did the consequence fit the behaviour?
- What support would help the next attempt?

If you missed a day

Skip the guilt. Continue with the next useful step. A reset is a tool, not another standard to fail.

Related tool

Support your reset with the Daily Routine Planner (Tool 3), the Weekly Family Review (Tool 7) and the 30-Day Habit Tracker (Tool 8). **See page 32.**



TOOLKIT

The Toolkit

Eight printable tools and 50 phrases to keep close. Print them or copy them into a notebook.

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PRINTABLE TOOL 1

Our Family Rules

01

Choose a few agreements. Post this where your family can see it.

Our rules help everyone know what to expect. Adults will teach and remind; children will get chances to practise. We will correct actions without insults, hitting or humiliation.

1

2

3

4

5

6

When a rule is broken, our fair next step is:

Child signature (optional)

Adult signature

Review after two weeks

Change a rule if it is unclear, unrealistic or no longer fits the child's age.

PRINTABLE TOOL 2

Weekly Chore Chart

02

Agree on the jobs, the time, and what “finished” looks like.

Job / person	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Done means...	Help needed	Review

Our daily chore time:

Adult check-in:

Use simple marks or stickers for younger children. A missed box is a cue to reset the plan, not a reason to shame anyone.

PRINTABLE TOOL 3

03

Daily Routine Planner

Make the busiest part of the day easier to see and share.

Time / cue	What happens next?	Who helps?
Wake-up		
Before school		
After school		
Homework		
Evening		
Bedtime		

The routine we most want to make calmer:

A reminder or visual cue we will try:

Keep the plan short. Add buffer for transport, meals, prayer, rest or family responsibilities as needed.

PRINTABLE TOOL 4

Behaviour Tracker

04

Track a specific behaviour for one week without labelling the child.

Behaviour we want to understand:

What we want to see instead:

Day	What happened before?	What did the child do?	What happened after?
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

A pattern we noticed:

Describe actions and context, not character. For example: "left the table twice during homework," not "is stubborn."

PRINTABLE TOOL 5

05

Consequence Planner

Plan while calm. Keep it connected, safe and possible to follow through.

Prompt	Our plan
What happened?	
What skill or repair is needed?	
What is the related next step?	
Is it age-appropriate and safe?	Yes / No — revise if needed
Can I follow through calmly?	Yes / No — choose a realistic option
What will I say?	

Fairness check

Would I choose the same response if I were calm? Is it about teaching or making the child suffer? Does it preserve basic care, safety and dignity?

When will we review the plan?

PRINTABLE TOOL 6

Parent Calm-Down Checklist

06

Use this before a hard conversation—or after you notice your voice rising.

- ☐ I notice my body: tight jaw, fast speech, clenched hands, hot face.
- ☐ I make sure everyone is physically safe.
- ☐ I take five slow breaths or step away briefly while the child is safe.
- ☐ I lower my voice and shorten my words.
- ☐ I name one expectation—not every past mistake.
- ☐ I choose a related consequence I can actually follow through on.
- ☐ If I need help, I ask a safe adult to take over.
- ☐ If I shouted, I plan a repair conversation.

My early warning signs are:

A person or practical support I can call on:

Reminder

A pause is not giving in. It is choosing to return with enough calm to teach.

PRINTABLE TOOL 7

07

Weekly Family Review

Ten minutes is enough. Each person gets a turn to speak and be heard.

Question	Notes
One thing that went well	
One helpful action we noticed	
A hard moment and what we learned	
A rule or routine to clarify	
One small goal for next week	
Who can help?	

Our next check-in date: _____ Time: _____

Keep the review curious, not prosecutorial. Do not use this meeting to list everything a child did wrong.

PRINTABLE TOOL 8

30-Day Discipline Habit Tracker

08

Track your own calm, consistent action—not a child's worth or perfection.

The parent habit I am practising:

The cue that will remind me:

1 ☐	2 ☐	3 ☐	4 ☐	5 ☐	6 ☐	7 ☐	8 ☐
9 ☐	10 ☐	11 ☐	12 ☐	13 ☐	14 ☐	15 ☐	16 ☐
17 ☐	18 ☐	19 ☐	20 ☐	21 ☐	22 ☐	23 ☐	24 ☐
25 ☐	26 ☐	27 ☐	28 ☐	29 ☐	30 ☐	Review ☐	Restart ☐

At the end of each week, ask

- What helped me pause?
- When was the routine hardest?
- What small adjustment will I try?

A missed day is information, not failure
Start again at the next opportunity.

QUICK REFERENCE

50 things to say instead of shouting

50

Choose a phrase that sounds natural. Calm does not mean weak.

Make the words yours

Use the language you naturally speak at home. A phrase works best when it is respectful, brief and followed by predictable action.

Getting ready and following instructions

- | | |
|--|--|
| 1 "Please put your shoes away now." | 6 "The bus is coming. Bag by the door now, please." |
| 2 "Look at me for a moment; I have one instruction." | 7 "You can do it yourself, or I can help you start." |
| 3 "First uniform, then breakfast." | 8 "Tell me what you heard me ask." |
| 4 "What is the first step you need to do?" | 9 "We are leaving in five minutes. Choose your shoes." |
| 5 "I will wait while you finish that step." | 10 "The instruction has not changed. Please begin." |

Chores, school and homework

- | | |
|--|--|
| 11 "Homework comes before phone time." | 16 "You have ten minutes to finish this part, then take a break." |
| 12 "Bring your books to the table; we will choose the first task." | 17 "I can help you understand the question; you will do the answer." |
| 13 "Please put your plate by the sink." | 18 "The clothes go in the basket, not on the floor." |
| 14 "Your chore is not finished yet. What is the last step?" | 19 "Show me where you got stuck." |
| 15 "Let us check the school bag together." | 20 "When the task is done, you can choose the next activity." |

Feelings and safety

- | | |
|---|--|
| 21 "You may be angry, but you may not hit your brother." | 26 "Let us take a minute and try again." |
| 22 "I can see you are upset. I am here." | 27 "You do not have to like the rule; it still applies." |
| 23 "I will listen when we can both speak safely." | 28 "It is okay to feel disappointed." |
| 24 "Hands down. I will help keep everyone safe." | 29 "I will not let you throw that. I am moving it for now." |
| 25 "You can tell me what happened without insults." | 30 "We can solve this after everyone is calm." |

Screens and transitions

- | | |
|--|---|
| 31 "Five minutes left. Save at the next checkpoint." | 34 "Would you like to switch it off, or shall I help?" |
| 32 "The phone rests in the family spot during dinner." | 35 "The plan is homework, then your agreed screen time." |
| 33 "You can finish this episode tomorrow; screen time is over now." | |

Siblings, visitors and public moments

- | | |
|--|--|
| 36 "I will hear each person. First, let us make sure everyone is safe." | 39 "We are stepping outside to settle, then we can talk." |
| 37 "Ask for a turn with words; do not grab." | 40 "I will not compare you with your sister. Let us focus on this problem." |
| 38 "We speak respectfully to visitors and to one another." | |

Repair, responsibility and encouragement

- | | |
|---|---|
| 41 "That action was not okay. You can help make it right." | 46 "What could help you remember next time?" |
| 42 "You told me the truth. Thank you for being honest." | 47 "You kept trying even when it was difficult." |
| 43 "You started after one reminder. That helped." | 48 "Would you like help, or do you want to try alone first?" |
| 44 "I shouted earlier. I am sorry. I will try again." | 49 "We are learning this together." |
| 45 "I love you, and the boundary still stands." | 50 "Let us make a new plan for tomorrow." |

CLOSING CHAPTER

The goal is not a perfect child

The goal is a child learning responsibility, boundaries and self-control—with your help.

Children will forget, test rules, argue and make mistakes. Adults will sometimes lose patience. What matters is the pattern built over time: clear expectations, safe limits, chances to practise, fair repair and reconnection after hard moments.

You do not need to change every routine this week. Choose one conflict that happens often. Make the instruction clearer. Decide what a fair next step looks like. Notice one moment when your child tries. If you shout, repair and restart. Small steady changes can make family life more workable, even when they do not make it perfect.

**Keep this sentence close**

“I can be kind and firm. I can teach without frightening. We can try again.”

Your child needs boundaries, and they also need to know they belong. You do not have to choose between respect and warmth. A calm voice may take practice; it is still a voice with authority.

About this guide

A practical resource for real family life — a guide to learn from, adapt, and return to.

This guide was created as general parenting education for Nigerian parents and caregivers of children approximately ages 3–15. It offers practical examples for routines, chores, school responsibilities, screens, siblings and emotional moments. Families differ; use your judgment, culture, language and trusted community support to adapt the ideas.

Disclaimer

This guide provides general parenting education and is not a substitute for individualized professional advice, assessment or support. It does not diagnose a child or caregiver. If a child's behaviour is persistently distressing, unsafe or interfering with daily life—or if you are worried about anyone's safety—seek advice from an appropriately qualified professional or relevant local service.

Selected sources and further reading

- UNICEF Parenting. “How to discipline your child the smart and healthy way.” unicef.org/parenting. Accessed September 2026.
- World Health Organization. *WHO guidelines on parenting interventions to prevent maltreatment and enhance parent–child relationships with children aged 0–17 years*. 2023. who.int.
- U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. “Positive Parenting Tips: Preschoolers (3–5 years old).” cdc.gov. Accessed September 2026.

Thank you for showing up for your child—and for yourself.